Journal of Ethnic and Cultural Studies
2026, Vol.13, No. 3, 229-251
http://dx.doi.org/10.29333/ejecs/2148

Copyright 2026
ISSN: 2149-1291

Experiences of Finnish Public Services: Barriers to Cultural Inclusion for Iranian Migrant Women

Zahra Hosseini[1]
University of Helsinki, Helsinki, Finland

Amir Pakpour Haji Agha & Thomas Olsson
Tampere University, Tampere, Finland

Abstract: This study aims to understand the challenges and obstacles Iranian migrant women face in their experiences with public services in Finland and how these challenges affect their cultural inclusion in Finnish society. The study draws on semi-structured face-to-face interviews with ten Iranian migrant women who have resided in Finland for 5 to 28 years, representing diverse backgrounds in terms of age, education, marital status, employment status, and migration pathways. The findings reveal multifaceted challenges that participants encounter in their sociocultural interactions, employment, and access to information in their engagement with public services in Finland, even after years of residence. In addition, the analysis highlights three cross-cutting barriers, language proficiency, limited social networks, and perceived or actual discrimination, that interconnect these challenges and significantly hinder migrants' sense of belonging. By applying the Equality, Diversity, and Inclusion (EDI) framework, this study offers new insights into the structural and interpersonal dynamics that shape cultural inclusion, providing actionable recommendations for policymakers, public service providers, and community organizations to promote equitable and sustainable integration.
Keywords: Cultural inclusion, EDI, immigrants, public services.

The recent surge in refugee migration to Europe has intensified scholarly and policy discussions on cultural integration. In response, the concepts, dimensions, and indicators of cultural integration have been increasingly developed through cross-disciplinary lenses, including sociology, migration studies, and public policy. Early debates on integration tended to focus on language acquisition (e.g., Li, 2013), behavioral adjustment (Slonim-Nevo et al., 2009), and initial settlement (e.g., Quirke, 2012). However, as migrants transition from newcomers to long-term residents, scholarly attention has shifted toward social inclusion, which entails meaningful participation (Nyström et al., 2023; Mohammadi, 2022), and equitable access to institutions and services (Safarov, 2024; Hosseini & Hytönen, 2022; Li & Wang, 2024; Zardo et al., 2023). This shift acknowledges that time alone may not ensure

[1] Corresponding author: Postdoctoral Researcher, Faculty of Social Science, University of Helsinki, Helsinki. Finland. E-Mail: zahra.hosseini@helsinki.fi
Copyright © 2026 by the author(s). Published by CECS Publications, United States. This is an open-access article distributed under the terms and conditions of the Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International License (CC BY 4.0), which permits unrestricted use, distribution, and reproduction in any medium, provided the original work is properly cited.

integration, but longer residence may expose migrants to deeper structural inequalities, including systemic discrimination and institutional exclusion.

Currently, language training and the promotion of equality are central strategies in many European countries for facilitating the social integration of immigrants (European Commission, 2024a). While these efforts aim to support inclusion, a growing body of research has documented the persistent discrimination against immigrants (e.g., Esses, 2021; Hosseini, in press). Discrimination can manifest in both overt and subtle forms, affecting access to workplaces (e.g., Gube & Arat, 2024), housing (e.g., Zhang et al., 2022; Bonnal et al., 2012), healthcare (e.g., Marchi et al., 2022; Hudelson et al., 2010), public institutions (e.g., Röder & Mühlau, 2011), and education (e.g., Borgonovi & Pokropek, 2019). Notably, recent studies have shown that even seemingly minor indicators, such as ethnically distinctive first names, can lead to unequal treatment and exclusion (Fernandez-Villa et al., 2025; Polavieja et al., 2023). Perceived discrimination further decreases equality, undermines institutional trust, and negatively impacts the overall sense of belonging (Hosseini, 2026; Tyrberg, 2024; Wu & Finnsdottir, 2021; Hussain & Jones, 2021).

While migrants' language training has been the key strategy for the social integration of immigrants in many European countries (European Commission, 2024a), the Action Plan on Integration and Inclusion 2021-2027 marks a broader approach. It emphasizes the development of equitable access to education and training, sustainable labor market integration, accessible healthcare, and adequate and affordable housing (European Commission, 2024b). Although this represents a significant policy shift, migrant participation and a genuine sense of belonging remain underdeveloped aspects of integration frameworks.

To address this gap, the present study explores how immigrants with long-term residence in Finland experience public services, with a focus on the challenges they face that influence their inclusion. Iranian immigrant women have been selected as the target group, representing a socio-culturally distinct and often underrepresented migrant population in Finnish research.

The study is structured around the following research questions:

1. What challenges do Iranian migrant women encounter in their experiences with Finnish public services?
2. How do these experiences shape their sense of cultural inclusion and belonging in Finnish society?

Theoretical Framework

Over time, European integration policies have shifted from an assimilationist concept, which placed the burden solely on migrants to conform to the dominant culture, toward a more inclusive understanding of integration. While assimilation implies a one-way process where a minority group adopts the culture of the dominant group, potentially losing aspects of their original culture, integration involves mutual adaptation between migrants and host societies, emphasizing cooperation, cultural recognition, and shared responsibility (Migration Policy Institute, 2021).

As the concept of integration has evolved, a range of theoretical frameworks has been developed or adapted from disciplines such as sociology, psychology, and education to better explain how immigrants adapt to host societies. These theories have undergone significant development over time, reflecting the increasing complexity of migration dynamics and social inclusion.

Journal of Ethnic and Cultural Studies
2026, Vol.13, No. 3, 229-251
http://dx.doi.org/10.29333/ejecs/2148
Copyright 2026
ISSN: 2149-1291

From Assimilation to Integration

One of the earliest frameworks, the Classical Assimilation Theory, posits that immigrants gradually adopt the cultural and social norms of the dominant society in a linear, one-way process that often results in a loss of their original culture. Over time and across generations, immigrants become culturally indistinguishable from the native population (Kalogrides, 2009). In contrast, the Segmented Assimilation Theory, developed by Portes and Zhou, challenges this linear model by arguing that assimilation pathways are diverse and shaped by contextual factors (Zhou, 2014). According to this theory, immigrant groups may experience upward mobility, downward assimilation into marginalized communities, or selective acculturation, depending on factors such as race, class, and community support (FitzGerald, 2025).

Building on these, the Theory of Social Assimilation focuses on the relational aspects of integration, emphasizing how immigrants gradually develop deeper social ties with members of the host society, leading to greater inclusion and reduced inequalities (de Palo et al., 2006). While sharing some assumptions with Classical Assimilation Theory, Social Assimilation Theory pays greater attention to structural access, such as employment, education, and social networks, and acknowledges that assimilation is neither uniform nor inevitable, but shaped by diverse conditions (FitzGerald, 2025).

Alongside these assimilation-based approaches, migration frameworks have moved toward understanding integration as a multidimensional and reciprocal process. For example, the Theory of Social Integration proposed by Bosswick and Heckmann (2007) represents such a shift. This model outlines four key dimensions: structural, cultural, interactive, and identificational integration. Structural integration refers to immigrants' access to the status and status of the host society, such as the labor market. Cultural integration focuses on increasing immigrants' knowledge and activities about culture and society, such as language training. Interactive integration means the inclusion of immigrants in the relationships and social networks of society. Identificational integration means that an immigrant has a sense of belonging and identity with the host community groups (Bosswick & Heckmann, 2007).

Despite its comprehensive approach, some scholars argue that social integration theory remains conceptually underdeveloped and empirically difficult to operationalize (Rogova, 2014; Shangguan et al., 2019). The theory’s complexity, combined with the contextual and multidimensional nature of cultural processes, continues to pose challenges for researchers and policymakers seeking to design effective integration strategies. These theoretical developments illustrate a broader shift in migration studies, from viewing integration as a one-sided process of cultural loss to recognizing it as a dynamic, reciprocal, and context-dependent journey.

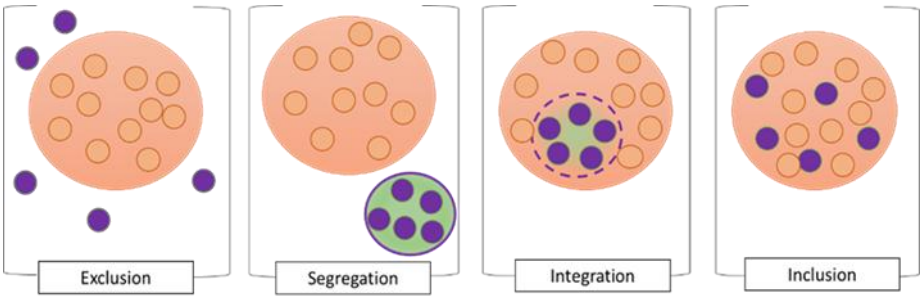
From Integration to Inclusion

While most migration theories approach integration from a sociological perspective, this study explores cultural inclusion, a step beyond integration, through an educational lens. With the rise of cultural diversity in classrooms, attention to inclusion gained prominence in the United States around 2014, emphasizing the importance of ensuring that all individuals, regardless of background, feel valued, respected, and empowered within a group or institution (Drexel University School of Education, n.d.).

Over the past decade, the concept of cultural inclusion has become increasingly prevalent in educational discourse, often distinguished from related terms like integration and assimilation. For example, Sónia (2012) visualizes inclusion as the final stage in a four-part progression: exclusion, segregation, integration, and ultimately, inclusion (see Figure 1).

Figure 1

The Continuum from Exclusion to Inclusion (Adapted from Sónia, 2012)



In this figure, exclusion refers to the denial of participation for minority groups in society because they are perceived as "abnormal." Segregation involves the physical or social separation of marginalized groups, such as racial, religious, or gender minorities. Integration refers to individuals who successfully adapt and are considered part of society. Cultural inclusion encompasses societal acceptance and structural mechanisms that allow migrants to fully engage in economic, social, and civic life, regardless of their cultural background.

Over time, cultural inclusion has been conceptualized as a part of the broader Equality/Equity, Diversity, and Inclusion (EDI/DEI) framework, which aims to foster belonging and meaningful participation (Nguyen et al., 2023). Initially rooted in education, EDI/DEI strategies have now expanded across diverse sectors. Recent studies have applied EDI/DEI in organizational and management contexts (Prashar, 2025; Adeyemi Abdulwasiu, 2024; Hamidullah et al., 2024), political discourse (Abrica et al., 2024; Ng et al., 2025), human rights frameworks (Vissing, 2025), and even in tourism (Coleman, 2018; Olivares & Piatak, 2022). In education, EDI/DEI remains a foundational model (Corsino et al., 2021; Cumming et al., 2023; Cox et al., 2023), offering tools to evaluate belonging and equitable participation.

As societies become increasingly diverse and multicultural, promoting the inclusion of immigrants and fostering social cohesion has emerged as a strategic priority in international policy agendas. Notably, the United Nations Sustainable Development Goal 16 emphasizes the importance of fostering peaceful and inclusive societies, ensuring access to justice for all, and building effective, accountable, and inclusive institutions at all levels (United Nations, n.d.). This global commitment raises pressing questions about how governments address migration-related challenges, particularly in enhancing cultural inclusion. In response, recent migration studies have begun to place greater emphasis on cultural inclusion as a key component of integration policy and practice (Sgaramella, 2024; Kupriianova & Kupriianova, 2023; Salgado & Patuzzi, 2022; Echeverría & Finotelli, 2024). In this context, the present study proposes using the EDI framework to understand how a marginalized migrant group, Iranian migrant women, experience and interact with public services in Finland, and how these experiences reflect or hinder cultural inclusion.

Context of the Study

Finland's relatively brief history as an immigration country, remaining largely closed to migration until the 1980s (Paananen, 1999), means that multiculturalism is a comparatively recent societal reality. However, it has developed progressive integration policies, as reflected in its high scores on the Migrant Integration Policy Index (MIPEX, 2024). Yet, Immigrants continue to face significant challenges, such as language barriers, discrimination, and social prejudices, which hinder their ability to fully integrate and contribute to persistent inequalities compared to Finnish natives (Brennan-Masters, 2024). These challenges highlight the gap between formal policy commitments and lived experiences of inclusion.

Journal of Ethnic and Cultural Studies
2026, Vol.13, No. 3, 229-251
http://dx.doi.org/10.29333/ejecs/2148
Copyright 2026
ISSN: 2149-1291

According to the Finnish Institute for Health and Welfare (FIHW, 2022), inclusion is "everyone's right to health, education, work, income, housing, and social relationships" alongside the ability to participate in decision-making and influence societal development. In practice, the process of cultural inclusion for migrants is closely linked to labor market participation (Laurén & Wrede, 2008), which is considered both an important mechanism for social equality and a central task of public services (Ministry of Justice, 1999). However, migrants in Finland face significant challenges in finding jobs that match their skills and qualifications, which can be a crucial source of inequality and hinder inclusion (Brennan-Masters, 2024; Nichols & Virsinger, 2021).

Given the complexity and multidimensional nature of cultural integration, diverse research approaches and community-based activities are needed to provide a more comprehensive understanding of how migrants become included in society. In this context, ensuring that public services remain accessible, responsive, and of high quality for all citizens, including migrants, has become a policy priority (Baredes, 2022).

Situated within the broader Trust-M project, which investigates the development of trustworthy and inclusive digital public services for migrants, this study explores how migrants' experiences with public services influence their inclusion in society.

Research Method

An exploratory qualitative study was designed to understand the phenomenon and aspects of cultural inclusion among Iranian migrant women, shaped by their interactions with public sector services in Finland. Prior studies in Finland have largely focused on larger migrant populations such as Russian (Glushkova et al., 2025; Buchert et al., 2023; Stasulane, 2024) or Somalian groups (Ismail, 2023; Kontkanen, 2024; Mohamed, 2024) in the context of lived experiences and belonging. While previous research has examined migrant integration, information access, and communication more broadly (Hosseini & Hytönen, 2022; Hosseini et al., 2020; Hosseini & Kotilainen, 2022), these works have not focused specifically on Iranian women or their interactions with public services. Iranians represent a relatively small migrant group in the country, yet they are socioculturally diverse due to Iran's intricate political, ethnic, and religious landscape. As women often face increased vulnerabilities related to gender, migration, and systemic exclusion (EMN, 2022; Thanh & Bao Duong, 2024; Gilodi et al., 2024), their perspectives on public service interactions are both critical and underrepresented. This research, therefore, contributes to closing that gap by focusing on a group that may face distinct cultural, linguistic, and institutional barriers in accessing and navigating public services.

Participants were recruited through Iranian community channels, including Facebook groups, Telegram, and WhatsApp networks. Eligibility required a minimum of five years' residency in Finland to ensure a baseline of integration experience and public service exposure. Ten migrant women participated in the study, which reflects both the relatively small size of the Iranian female migrant population and the ethical and contextual sensitivities involved in recruiting participants for a study connected to public institutions (Hosseini & Olsson, 2026; Shah, 2024). Striving for inclusion while countering self-selection bias poses a significant methodological challenge, particularly in research involving vulnerable or marginalized populations (Markova, 2009; Shah, 2024). However, despite the small sample size, the study adhered to qualitative rigor and recruitment efforts until thematic saturation was reached (Fusch et al., 2018).

The participants demonstrated diversity across multiple dimensions, including age, educational background, marital status, migration pathways, employment situation, and length

of residency in Finland. Notably, six of the ten participants were living independently at the time of the study, either due to divorce or single status (see Table 1).

Table 1
Demographics of the Participants

Participants	Age	Residency	Years	Entry	Education	job
Maryam	30	Non	5	Study	Master	Job seeker
Ziba	36	Non	7	Study	Postdoc researcher	Researcher
Yasi	48	Non	6	Study	Self-funded PhD	Job seeker
Bita	62	Resident	24	Refugee	Bachelor	Nurse
Parvin	48	Resident	28	Refugee	Finnish system	Ent.
Mahsa	34	Resident	12	Refugee	Finnish sys	Ent.
Laleh	43	Resident	10	Refugee	bachelor	Teacher
Sara	53	Resident	17	Refugee	Finnish sys.	Nurse
Elham	42	Resident	7	Marriage	PhD researcher	Job seeker
Shirin	40	Resident	19	Marriage	Bachelor	Teacher

The interviews were conducted in the native language of the participants (i.e., Persian) by the first author, a native speaker of Iranian descent. This shared linguistic and cultural background between the interviewer and participants contributed to greater contextual sensitivity and minimized the risk of misinterpretation or misplaced emphasis on culturally embedded meanings (Neyer & Harzing, 2008).

The duration of each interview ranged from 50 to 75 minutes, and the interviews encompassed a diverse cross-section of migrants, continuing until it was evident that no further novel insights could be extracted regarding the phenomenon under scrutiny. All interviews were recorded with informed consent, transcribed verbatim in Persian, and subsequently translated into English. Each participant was initially assigned a numerical code, which was later replaced with a pseudonym during the data analysis process to ensure confidentiality.

To enhance trustworthiness and reduce potential researcher bias, a second native-speaking researcher (second author) collaborated as a peer reviewer for the English translations and coding, ensuring accuracy and semantic consistency. Transcripts were uploaded into Atlas.ti software for systematic analysis. The coding process was carried out manually, with active collaboration and discussion among all authors. Following the principles of exploratory qualitative research and thematic analysis, an inductive approach was applied (Boyatzis, 1998). Meaningful quotations were coded, patterns identified, and themes iteratively developed.

Given the focus on migrants in Finland, the research team placed paramount emphasis on ethical considerations. This entailed a) upholding the dignity and autonomy of the human research participants, b) demonstrating respect for tangible and intangible cultural heritage and biodiversity, and c) vigilantly assessing the potential risks or harm that might affect participants and communities. In addition to the overarching Trust-M project's ethical approval, this sub-project received separate clearance from the Research Ethics Review Committee of the University of Tampere, Finland, due to the sensitivity of the target group. The approval was granted on 23 March 2023, following the ethical policy guidelines of the Finnish National Board on Research Integrity (TENK), before starting the project.

Findings

The results of the study investigating the cultural inclusion development process among participants, through their interactions with public services, revealed a nuanced array of challenges. These challenges were identified through an inductive thematic analysis and are categorized into three key thematic domains: sociocultural, employment, and access to

Journal of Ethnic and Cultural Studies
2026, Vol.13, No. 3, 229-251
http://dx.doi.org/10.29333/ejecs/2148
Copyright 2026
ISSN: 2149-1291

information, which emerged directly from patterns observed in participants' narratives. These categories reflect the most frequently discussed and commonly experienced issues across the dataset. Each category emerged through thematic analysis in Atlas.ti, highlighting the interconnections between sociocultural interactions, information access, and employment barriers.

The following sections of the paper present a detailed analysis of each theme, illustrated with direct quotations from participants to deepen contextual understanding and support the interpretation of findings.

Sociocultural Challenges

In the domain of sociocultural interaction, participants described a wide range of experiences in both formal and informal settings. These included instances of discrimination, being underestimated, and, conversely, positive encounters characterized by respect and helpfulness.

One of the most significant barriers participants encountered in formal interactions referred to dealing with public institutions, completing bureaucratic tasks, or workplace communication. This barrier did not affect all participants equally; rather, its impact varied based on immigrants' educational background, career field, and their English language skills.

For participants in professions that require direct communication with clients or public authorities, such as healthcare or municipal services, knowing Finnish is essential. For example, Sara, a nurse assistant with 17 years of residency in Finland, described how the language barrier remains a persistent obstacle in her formal responsibilities, such as reports and patient records:

> "The language barrier is still my biggest problem, especially when I need to deal with official documents."

In contrast, highly educated participants working in international academic or research settings, where English is often the working language, reported fewer immediate pressures to learn Finnish. However, they still encountered difficulties when navigating Finnish public systems. Yasi, a PhD researcher, reflected on her experience:

> "It (learning the Finnish language) takes a lot of time. I passed some Finnish language courses at the university, but I felt that my skills in communicating or even reading Finnish letters were still inadequate. So, I gave up."

She often used digital applications to translate letters and official documents.

Participants' informal interactions with Finnish staff and citizens in public service contexts revealed a spectrum of experiences, ranging from deeply supportive to disheartening or discriminatory. Several participants recounted unexpected acts of support from Finnish individuals, which left a lasting impression on their perception of Finnish society. These included assistance from supervisors, colleagues, or NGO staff during critical moments in their integration journey. For instance, Bita recalled the helpfulness of colleagues during her immigration process, while Laleh received settlement support from volunteers at Setlementti, a Finnish NGO. Sara shared how a former employer helped her secure a new job, and Ziba noted support from her supervisor. These moments of personal attention were often interpreted as signs of respect and responsibility. Sara expressed appreciation for the efforts of a public sector lawyer during a court case:

> "She followed my case in court so much and recounted my story nicely. She had included all the documents that I did not know".

Such experiences appeared to foster a sense of belonging and trust, as reflected in statements by participants like Bita, Sara, Shirin, and Elham.

However, not all informal interactions were experienced positively. Several participants expressed frustration with Finnish staff's communication style, often describing it as overly formal, impersonal, or lacking contextual sensitivity. Ziba noted,

> "Finnish people only answer your question… Answers are short and focused. But I often need to know more details." Mahsa compared bureaucratic responses to automated messaging: "It seems an artificial intelligence is behind the face…"

Unfamiliarity with the Finnish systems placed participants in an unequal and demanding position.

Some participants reported mistreatment or a lack of empathy, particularly from younger employees. Parvin, after living in Finland for 28 years and becoming fluent in Finnish, started her own business. Despite her accomplishments, she still felt like an outsider and referred to herself as a foreigner rather than a citizen, or even an immigrant. She shared her experiences in public service during a time when her entrepreneurial endeavors were at risk:

> "I was sick… that 22/23-year-old employee was so rude. I wondered how other foreigners handle this."

Elham highlighted the consequences of short-term staffing, leading to service errors and misbehaviors. She exemplified her experience on how to face that:

> "They thought I had rejected a job offer. It took me a long time to prove otherwise."

Beyond the communication issue, perceptions of discrimination and racism were expressed in various forms and situations. For example, Ziba felt her academic work was undervalued unless validated by Finnish colleagues:

> "The project leader underestimated my work in the meeting… but appreciated it when a Finn colleague presented, who does a simple job."

Also, Elham referred to long-term "hidden racism," while Yasi noted that many Asian Ph.D. students were underemployed or working outside academia.

Participants also shared personal experiences of marginalization, like how Mahsa left her job after HR failed to address workplace harassment by a Finnish man. Elham recalled a custody dispute where a social office staff member sided with her Finnish husband and blamed her instead. Maryam and Laleh also described negative attitudes from several Finnish clients, ranging from derogatory remarks to a lack of confidence in their competence and the quality of their work.

The findings indicated how the varying levels and diversity of linguistic abilities in both English and Finnish among the participants can significantly impact their sociocultural interactions with public services. However, their feelings of discrimination and exclusion from Finnish networks impede their inclusion and sense of belonging within society.

Information Access Challenges

The theme of access to information highlighted the importance of information acquisition to migrants' ability to integrate and make informed decisions. While initial information was often gathered from family, integration programs, or universities, participants indicated a strong dependence on external sources, particularly search engines like Google, as well as advice from peers and acquaintances, to remain updated.

Those with refugee backgrounds typically benefited from structured cultural integration services, which provided practical guidance for navigating life in Finland. Although Laleh arrived in Finland as a single woman, she had no negative memories of her arrival and instead appreciated the support and empathy provided by the service providers. She noted:

> "They provide so much information, enabling newcomers to figure out what to do and how to manage."

Journal of Ethnic and Cultural Studies
2026, Vol.13, No. 3, 229-251
http://dx.doi.org/10.29333/ejecs/2148
Copyright 2026
ISSN: 2149-1291

In contrast, individuals arriving through family reunification often relied on their spouse or relatives for informal guidance and access to wider networks. For example, Elham shared,

> "The only channel [of information] was my husband... He also had several friends and gave me their phone numbers."

International students, who are generally excluded from formal integration services, depend largely on universities for support. However, they were often left to manage their integration independently, which many found challenging.

> "Access to this information is poor."

said Ziba, who had a position at the university and received more support than other participants of this study who came on study permits.

Although the Finnish integration system offers a comprehensive framework, continued access to updated and practical information relies heavily on one's ability to build and maintain connections with institutions and communities, such as social services, Setlementti, or Neuvola (two Finnish NGOs). Yet not all migrants feel confident or welcome in these spaces. Mahsa illustrated this point:

> "Every time I went there [Social Office], I saw immigrants lined up… I understood that they would come even if they had nothing to do."

Informal network friends, peers, or colleagues also played a crucial role in facilitating information exchange (Sara, Shirin, Maryam, Ziba, Yasi).

Limited access to accurate or timely information sometimes had serious consequences. While occasionally leading to unexpected positive outcomes, it also resulted in missed opportunities or legal and financial vulnerabilities. Elham shared that during her divorce, she was unaware of her rights due to the assumption that she understood the system:

> "There were times when they [service providers] trusted my knowledge too much, and I did not know my rights."

The analysis of the findings highlighted that limited access to reliable information exposes participants to unequal, unconscious, and systematic discrimination. This lack of access reduces their sense of inclusion and drives them towards informal communities for information, which may not be as trustworthy as official sources.

Employment Challenges

Under employment-related challenges, participants reported various barriers to job entry, negative workplace dynamics, and difficulties in pursuing entrepreneurial initiatives.

Many participants expressed confusion regarding employment rules and regulations:

> "I was sure something was missing in my job applications; it could be the style of writing, my network, good recommendations, or language proficiency."

Yasi stated. On the other hand, most participants discussed the role of social networks in finding a suitable job (Ziba, Elham, Yasi, Laleh, and Mahsa).

Educated participants found job searching particularly difficult. Yasi, a PhD researcher who has been unable to find a job for years, was unsure what was missing from her job applications. She stated in a despairing voice:

> "They have their own network and know the language, and this country belongs to them. So, they are entitled to these (job) positions".

Maryam, holding two master's degrees, noted:

> "I think I've received about 350 rejection letters. They always say that others are better than I, so they reject me. But they never specify why they (other applicants) are superior." Ziba noted, "At the university,

> they tried to support international students, but in the job market, Finns are clearly prioritized."

Several participants believed migrants are funneled into low-level positions. Parvin, after 28 years in Finland, stated,

> "They mostly use foreigners for the hard, low-level work." Maryam added, "They feel more comfortable when we are in a lower position."

As mentioned in previous sections, discriminatory behavior at work was also reported in different forms and situations. Laleh observed,

> "Foreigners are given more work. When it gets busy, Finns often step back."

Mahsa shared an experience of workplace harassment dismissed by HR, which she perceived as rooted in racism. Parvin, disillusioned by such conditions, turned to self-employment:

> "I didn't have the patience. I wanted to work independently as a hairstylist."

Three participants had entrepreneurial experiences and found initial support from employment services helpful. However, sustaining their businesses proved difficult due to skepticism about their credibility. Laleh, who was importing dates from Iran as part of her business, said,

> "Business is tough for foreigners. You need a Finnish partner or a lot of money, which we don't have."

She noted that having a Finnish name beside hers would have increased trust. Mahsa, who runs a photography company, faced similar issues despite meeting all professional criteria:

> "They underestimated me because I'm a foreigner. That was discrimination."

Overall, findings revealed interconnected challenges participants encountered in both formal and informal sociocultural interactions with public services, employment, and information access, which could collectively hinder their cultural inclusion. For instance, while finding a job is an important challenge, limited access to information and opportunities for public services can heighten migrants' vulnerability and worsen inequality and deprivation. While these findings are based on participants' personal perceptions and lived experiences, and thus not intended for broad generalization, they offer valuable insights into the challenges faced by migrants navigating employment and integration in Finland.

Discussion

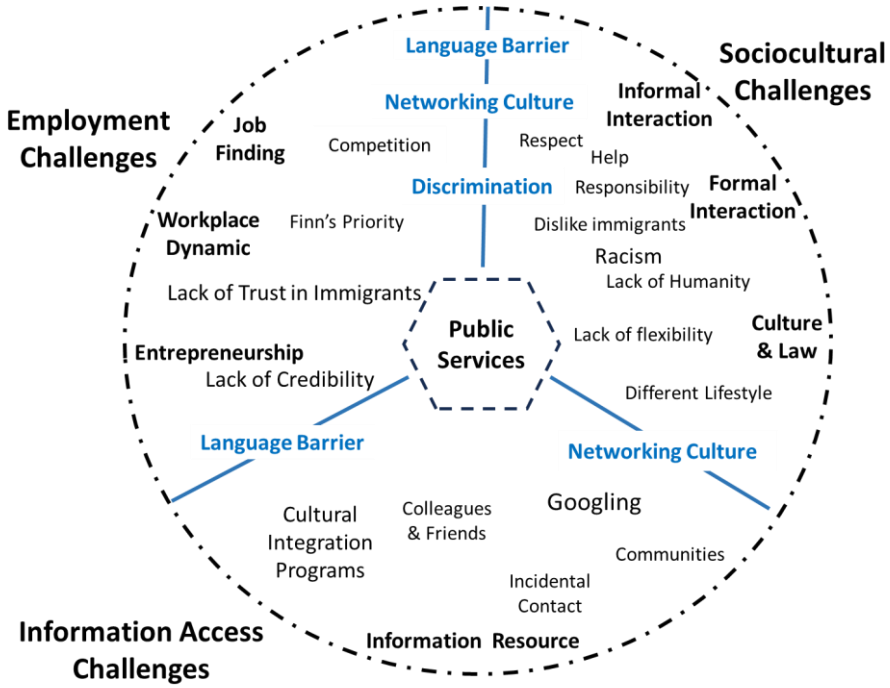
The analysis of participants' narratives revealed three key challenges shaping migrants' experiences in Finland: access to information, sociocultural experiences, and employment-related challenges. These challenges are deeply interconnected and are reinforced by three recurring barriers: language, limited social networks, and perceived or actual discrimination, which can hinder cultural inclusion (see Figure 2). These interconnected barriers influence migrants' experiences with public services to varying degrees and in different ways. The following sections explore each of these cross-cutting elements, language, social networks, and discrimination, to understand their role in shaping migrants' cultural inclusion through the Equality, Diversity, and Inclusion (EDI) framework.

Journal of Ethnic and Cultural Studies
2026, Vol.13, No. 3, 229-251
http://dx.doi.org/10.29333/ejecs/2148

Copyright 2026
ISSN: 2149-1291

Figure 2

Interconnected Challenges of Migrants' Experiences with Public Services



Language Skills as a Dimension of Diversity

Within the EDI framework, diversity refers to the recognition and valuing of differences, including differences in language, culture, identity, and experience (Golubeva, 2025). In the context of migration, language is more than a communicative tool for inclusion (Giavrimis & Dimitriadou, 2023); it is a key dimension of cultural identity, social recognition, and access to societal resources (Ambang, 2023; Bruijnzeel et al., 2022).

The relationship between language fluency and sociocultural adaptation is acknowledged, with indicators such as Finnish language proficiency, education, labor market participation, and social networks playing critical roles (Ghaffar et al., 2014; Hietalahti, 2022). According to the Foreign Service Institute (FSI), Finnish ranks among the most difficult languages for native English speakers to learn (FSI, n.d.). Migrants frequently encounter difficulties in acquiring Finnish, especially those from non-European backgrounds or with limited formal education (Hietalahti, 2022). According to the Finnish Institute for Health and Welfare (THL), nearly half of the foreign-background population identifies language barriers as a key obstacle to employment. Moreover, prejudices and hidden discrimination often manifest through rigid language requirements: over 75% of companies reportedly hesitate to hire those not fluent in Finnish, although language proficiency is not always essential for job performance. Interestingly, the Finnish Institute of Occupational Health's Diversity Barometer found that most HR professionals (88%) acknowledged that a perfect command of Finnish or Swedish is not necessary for all positions (THL, n.d.). In numerous studies, language skills, particularly proficiency in Finnish, serve as a crucial gateway to full participation in society, influencing various aspects such as employment opportunities, social interaction, and navigation of institutions. (Karanja, 2019; Mölsä et al., 2019; Nshom et al., 2022; E2 Research, 2023; Ndomo & Lillie, 2023).

Despite the emphasis on Finnish, English plays an increasingly significant role in migrants' everyday communication. Educated participants in this study described English as a

practical substitute, especially in urban environments and professional contexts where Finnish language proficiency is limited (Iikkanen, 2017). English proficiency is notably high in the Nordic countries: 81% of Finns report being able to hold a conversation in English (European Commission, 2024a). While Finnish and Swedish are the official languages, English is widely spoken and understood in Finland, making it relatively easy to navigate daily life, work, and studies without needing Finnish (Leppänen et al., 2011; Peterson, 2022a, 2022b; Edunation, n.d.; Helsinki Times, 2016). This widespread use of English provides migrants with a temporary communication bridge and access to initial employment, education, or services (Leinamo, 2022), although it may not fully replace the need for Finnish in long-term inclusion.

As language strongly shapes how individuals are understood and included, recognizing linguistic diversity is central to EDI efforts (Probyn-Rapsey, 2021). Promoting inclusive language practices and addressing structural language barriers can foster more equitable opportunities and belonging for migrants, beyond mere employment participation (Language Network, n.d.).

Networking Culture as a Dimension of Inclusion

Within the framework of Equality, Diversity, and Inclusion (EDI), networking culture is closely associated with the inclusion dimension. Inclusion focuses on creating environments where all individuals feel welcomed, valued, respected, and empowered to participate fully. Networking, an important process of inclusion, is defined by the Oxford Dictionary as "the action or process of interacting with others to exchange information and develop professional or social contacts." In the context of migration, networking is crucial for accessing hidden opportunities and the job market, understanding the local work culture, building social and professional support, and building a personal brand (Migrant Career, n.d.; Can & Soylu, 2025).

However, networks play an important role in finding a job. According to Sitra's 2017 Working Life Survey, only about one in four people find employment in an open position. Hidden jobs are often found through networks (Sitra, 2017). The results of this study, along with previous research, indicate that most migrants in the studies perceived the network as part of Finnish culture and believed in its important role in discovering job opportunities more than the TE office (Pehkonen, 2006; Alho, 2020; Nshom et al., 2022). Alho (2020) mentions that immigrants who were aware of public-sector recruitment practices believed that informal networks also played a role in public-sector recruitment (Pehkonen, 2006). They explained that jobs are not always open to public competition and, therefore, who you know is important in the public sector (Alho, 2020).

The strong network culture in Finland creates a challenge to the cultural inclusion of migrants and portrays it as a homogeneous country. Raento et al. (2001) argue that "The image of Finland as a culturally and ethnically homogeneous nation is erroneous. The reasons included the country's geographical location and its non-colonialist history". Statistics from Nordic Co-operation indicate that, in 2019, Finland had the second-lowest number of accepted immigrants, only surpassing Iceland (Nordic Co-operation, 2019). Compared to several other European countries, such as the Netherlands, France, the United Kingdom, and Belgium, Finland's migrant population is relatively small, and multiculturalism is not as firmly established (Sabour, 2023).

Exploring potential avenues, such as strengthening collaborative small communities or mitigating the influence of local social networks in pivotal decisions (e.g., legal matters, recruitments), is crucial to increasing the cultural inclusion of immigrants. As Shaymardanov et al. (2023) researchers found that although skilled immigrant women often face challenges in accessing career networks, they could overcome such barriers through their personal initiatives and with support from supervisors, colleagues, family members, and friends. The authors conclude that, however, sustainable inclusion also requires targeted organizational

Journal of Ethnic and Cultural Studies
2026, Vol.13, No. 3, 229-251
http://dx.doi.org/10.29333/ejecs/2148
Copyright 2026
ISSN: 2149-1291

arrangements that ensure equitable access to professional and social opportunities (Shaymardanov et al., 2023).

Discrimination as a Hindrance to Equality

Discrimination and inequality remain significant challenges in migration, affecting migrants at all stages of their journey. Migrants may encounter discrimination based on origin, ethnicity, gender, or migration status, which can limit their access to rights, opportunities, and social inclusion. While many contemporary societies have developed strategies to counter racism and discrimination, those practices persist, often subtly, through underestimating migrants' competencies, withholding trust, questioning transparency, or casting suspicious, prejudiced looks, as the participants of this study experienced. Such behaviours, occurring in both formal and informal interactions, are difficult to document, report, or prove.

In Finland, equality and justice are core societal values, and the Non-Discrimination Ombudsman has a mandate to promote equality nationwide. Despite robust cultural integration programs, discrimination remains a significant issue. Attitudes towards migrants in Finland are, in many respects, comparable to those in other EU countries (Ministry of Justice, 2021). A recent survey (Yle, 2024) found that over 40% of immigrants reported experiencing discrimination in the past year, often related to their background, ethnicity, or visible characteristics such as hair color. These experiences have consequences for both mental and physical health, as well as for broader social integration.

Discrimination in Finland is multifaceted, involving both interpersonal prejudice and structural barriers. Participants in this study described instances of misbehavior from public service staff (e.g., Kela) and harassment in the workplace, perceived as personal discrimination. While heightened cultural sensitivity among migrants may intensify the perception of discrimination, extensive research confirms that such experiences are not merely a matter of perception; they represent real obstacles to inclusion and belonging.

Beyond individual acts, structural racism limits migrant opportunities in sectors such as employment (Karanja, 2019; Victor, 2025). Ndomo (2024) observes that Finnish migration and labor regulations contribute to constructing migrants as a subordinated class of workers, often excluded from the protections and privileges of the egalitarian Finnish labor market and welfare system. Participants in this study echoed this, noting that migrants are often expected to occupy low-status jobs., According to the European Migration Network (2022), "The weak labor market position of migrant women can be seen as the greatest challenge related to their integration at present. Employment is a significant factor in successful integration, and it has wide-ranging impacts on individual well-being" (p. 4).

While proficiency in Finnish is widely acknowledged as crucial for employment (Hahl & Paavola, 2015; Thakur, 2025; Victor, 2025), some evidence suggests that language requirements can also serve as a pretext for avoiding the recruitment of migrants, creating a form of hidden but systematic discrimination (Yle, 2021). Beyond language proficiency, previous research has identified other justifications for discriminatory practices in migrant entrepreneurship, including doubts about the credibility of migrants' qualifications (e.g., Karanja, 2019; E2 Research, 2023), distrust toward immigrant-owned businesses (e.g., Aaltonen & Akola, 2012; Hosseini, in press), and heightened barriers for refugees in the workplace (Merikoski, 2021; Fath, 2019).

Experiences of discrimination diminish migrants' participation in group and community activities, thereby undermining inclusion (KC et al., 2023). Nykänen (2013) further found a strong association between employment, quality of life, and sense of belonging, concluding that inequality directly constrains immigrant women's access to the Finnish labor market.

Contributions and Implications

This study makes several contributions to the scholarship on migration and cultural inclusion. It expands the Equality, Diversity, and Inclusion (EDI) framework by demonstrating its relevance in analysing how public service interactions influence a sense of belonging among migrants. Additionally, it emphasizes the lived experiences of Iranian migrant women, a small but underexplored demographic in Finland, revealing how the intersections of gender, migration status, and cultural differences create distinct barriers. Furthermore, the study provides empirical evidence on the interconnected roles of interaction, information access, and employment. It shows that language barriers, limited networks, and discrimination collectively hinder cultural inclusion.

The findings carry several implications for policymakers, public service institutions, and integration program designers. Strengthening multi-channel information delivery, investing in intercultural training for the public, training staff, and addressing hidden job markets through transparent and inclusive recruitment can reduce structural barriers to belonging. Similarly, inclusive service design, supported by digital tools and AI solutions (Hosseini & Mehdizadeh, 2025; Hosseini & Tupasela, 2025), can further mitigate biases linked to language, names, or accents. Collectively, these measures can convert evidence of existing gaps into effective strategies that promote migrants' cultural inclusion and enhance social cohesion.

Conclusion

Despite considerable theoretical and practical research on EDI in education and employment, its application to migration remains relatively underexplored. While inclusion is widely acknowledged as a crucial element of integration, scholarship on multicultural societies underscores the need to embed cultural diversity more explicitly into social inclusion measures (Hayter, 2009).

In the Finnish context, diversity is often framed through language acquisition and labour market participation within integration programs. While these are important, meaningful integration requires a broader focus on social justice, sustainability, tolerance, and equitable employment opportunities, alongside the protection of migrants' rights (Stephen, 2024). We argue that cultural integration can be strengthened by emphasizing language training, access to relevant information, and opportunities for interaction. However, achieving sustainable integration ultimately depends on fostering cultural inclusion, which is essential for building a genuine sense of belonging among migrants.

This study highlights directions for future research. Longitudinal research can illustrate how barriers such as language, information gaps, and discrimination evolve. Additionally, comparative and intersectional studies would clarify whether these patterns are unique or systemic. Moreover, empirical studies that utilize the EDI framework to evaluate practical interventions, such as intercultural education, inclusive employment, and network support, can offer valuable insights for policy and practice.

Acknowledgment

This research was supported by the Trust-M project, which provided a valuable collaborative environment for the development of this study. The author also extends appreciation to all participants who contributed to this research.

Copyright 2026
ISSN: 2149-1291

Funding Details

The study is supported by the Research Council of Finland (Suomen Akatemia, www.aka.fi), grant number: 353510. The funders had no role in the study design, data collection and analysis, decision to publish, or preparation of the manuscript.

Authors Contributions

In this study, Z.H. contributed to the research design, conceptualization, data collection, and analysis. She also prepared the manuscript and managed all correspondence related to its submission. A.H.P. contributed to data collection, participated in some interviews, and assisted with translation, coding, and thematic analysis**.** T.O. contributed to research design, ethics approval, and provided feedback throughout the research process.

Ethics Statement

This project received clearance from the Research Ethics Review Committee of the University of Tampere, Finland. The approval was granted on 23 March 2023, following the ethical policy guidelines of the Finnish National Board on Research Integrity (TENK).

Data Availability Statement

The data that support the findings of this study are available upon request from the corresponding author. The data are not publicly available due to privacy or ethical restrictions.

Conflicts of Interest

The authors unequivocally affirm the absence of any known conflicts of interest that may be relevant to this article.

Publisher's note

All claims expressed in this article are solely those of the authors and do not necessarily represent those of their affiliated organizations, or those of the publisher, the editors and the reviewers. Any product that may be evaluated in this article, or claim that may be made by its manufacturer, is not guaranteed or endorsed by the publisher.

References

Aaltonen, S., & Akola, E. (2012, May 23–25). *Lack of trust: The main obstacle for immigrant entrepreneurship?* Nordic Conference on Small Business Research, Helsinki, Finland. http://pyk2.aalto.fi/ncsb2012/Aaltonen.pdf

Abrica, E. J., & Oliver, A. R. (2024). The racial politics of diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) work. *Journal of Diversity in Higher Education.* Advance online publication. https://doi.org/10.1037/dhe0000566

Adeyemi Abdulwasiu, A. (2024). Managing diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) through human resources management to enhance organizational profitability. *Fuoye Journal of Management Science, 1*(1), 1–15. https://kwasuspace.kwasu.edu.ng/items/21917dfc-1d4d-43b7-a724-a2ea75e7885b

Alho, R. (2020). You need to know someone who knows someone: International students' job-search experiences. *Nordic Journal of Working Life Studies, 10*(2), 3–22. https://doi.org/10.18291/njwls.v10i2.120817

Ambang, D. (2023). *Role of language in integration: Immigrants' perspectives* (Master's thesis). Metropolia University of Applied Sciences. https://urn.fi/URN:NBN:fi:amk-202304195579

Baredes, B. (2022). Serving citizens: Measuring the performance of services for a better user experience. *OECD Working Papers on Public Governance,* (52), 3–53. https://doi.org/10.1787/65223af7-en

Bonnal, L., Boumahdi, R., & Favard, P. (2012). Nonexpected discrimination: The case of social housing in France. *Applied Economics Letters, 19*(18), 1909–1916. https://doi.org/10.1080/13504851.2012.676727

Borgonovi, F., & Pokropek, A. (2019). Education and attitudes toward migration in a cross-country perspective. *Frontiers in Psychology, 10,* 2224. https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2019.02224

Bosswick, W., & Heckmann, F. (2007). *Integration of migrants: Contribution of local and regional authorities.* European Foundation for the Improvement of Living and Working Conditions. https://policycommons.net/artifacts/1836349/integration-of-migrants/2578830/

Boyatzis, R. E. (1998). *Transforming qualitative information: Thematic analysis and code development*. Sage.

Brennan-Masters, L. (2024). *Barriers to opportunity for immigrants in Finland: A source of inequality* (bachelor's thesis, Metropolia University of Applied Sciences). https://www.theseus.fi/handle/10024/860299

Bruijnzeel, A., Yazilitas, D., Smeets, I., De Bruyckere, P., & Cramer, J. (2022). How diverse is diversity? An exploration of references to diversity in the recent literature in STEM higher education. *European Journal of STEM Education, 7*(1), 12. https://doi.org/10.20897/ejsteme/12667

Buchert, U., Kemppainen, L., Olakivi, A., Wrede, S., & Kouvonen, A. (2023). Is digitalisation of public health and social welfare services reinforcing social exclusion? The case of Russian-speaking older migrants in Finland. *Critical Social Policy, 43*(3), 375–400. https://doi.org/10.1177/02610183221105035

Can, B. H., & Soylu, C. H. (2025). Examining the 5th grade science textbook learning learning units in the context of values: Türkiye century education model. *Asia Pacific Journal of Education and Society, 13*(2), 5. https://doi.org/10.20897/apjes/17468

Coleman, L. E. (2018). *Understanding and implementing inclusion in museums.* Rowman & Littlefield.

Corsino, L., & Fuller, A. T. (2021). Educating for diversity, equity, and inclusion: A review of commonly used educational approaches. *Journal of Clinical and Translational Science, 5*(1), e169. https://doi.org/10.1017/cts.2021.834

Cox, R., Bernstein, S., & Roy, K. (2023). A guide to application of diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) principles for prelicensure nursing education. *Journal of Professional Nursing, 46,* 146–154. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.profnurs.2023.03.002

Cumming, T., Miller, M. D., & Leshchinskaya, I. (2023). DEI institutionalization: Measuring diversity, equity, and inclusion in postsecondary education. *Change: The Magazine of Higher Learning, 55*(1), 31–38. https://doi.org/10.1080/00091383.2023.2151802

De Palo, D., Faini, R., & Venturini, A. (2006). The social assimilation of immigrants (IZA Discussion Paper No. 2439). Institute of Labor Economics (IZA). https://papers.ssrn.com/sol3/papers.cfm?abstract_id=947460

Copyright 2026
ISSN: 2149-1291

Drexel University School of Education. (n.d.). The importance of diversity and multicultural awareness in education. Drexel University. Https://drexel.edu/soe/resources/student-teaching/advice/importance-of-cultural-diversity-in-classroom/

E2 Research. (2023, March 17). *Press release: New research on international talents in Finland.* https://www.e2.fi/en/news/all-news.html

Echeverría, G., & Finotelli, C. (2024). Inclusion and exclusion. In M. Borkert & M. T. Herrera (Eds.), *Research handbook on the sociology of migration* (pp. 452–468). Edward Elgar Publishing. https://www.e-elgar.com/shop/gbp/research-handbook-on-the-sociology-of-migration-9781839105456.html

Edunation. (n.d.). *Pathway to Europe: Do Finns speak English? Tracing English's influence over time.* https://www.edunation.co/blog/do-finns-speak-english

Esses, V. M. (2021). Prejudice and discrimination toward immigrants. *Annual Review of Psychology, 72*(1), 503–531. https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev-psych-080520-102803

European Commission. (2024a). Directorate-General for Education, Youth, Sport and Culture, & Verian. *Europeans and their languages – Report.* Publications Office of the European Union. https://data.europa.eu/doi/10.2766/28257

European Commission. (2024b). *Action plan on integration and inclusion 2021–2027.* https://eurocities.eu/wp-content/uploads/2020/11/Policy-Brief-EU-Action-Plan-on-Integration-and-Inclusion-2021-2027.pdf

European Migration Network (EMN). (2022). *Integration of migrant women: National report of Finland.* EMN Finland. https://home-affairs.ec.europa.eu/system/files/2022-11/emn_integration_of_migrant_women_fi_national_report_final.pdf

Fath, E. M. (2019). *The intersectional experiences of inclusion and exclusion among Muslim women in the Finnish labor market* (master's thesis, University of Eastern Finland). Http://urn.fi/urn:nbn:fi:uef-20200005

Fernandez-Villa, G., van Hall, M., & Dirkzwager, A. J. (2025). Sources of police legitimacy in Europe: The role of immigrant status and ethnic discrimination. *European Journal on Criminal Policy and Research, 31*(2), 211–232. https://doi.org/10.1093/esr/jcaa041

Finnish Institute for Health and Welfare (FIHW). (2022). *Migration and cultural diversity: Integration and inclusion.* https://thl.fi/en/web/migration-and-cultural-diversity/integration-and-inclusion

Finnish Institute for Health and Welfare (THL). (n.d.). *A language aware approach*. https://thl.fi/en/topics/migration-and-cultural-diversity/support-material/good-practices/a-language-aware-approach

FitzGerald, D. S. (2025). The limits and possibilities of segmented assimilation theory. *Ethnic and Racial Studies, 48*(8), 1633–1641. https://doi.org/10.1080/01419870.2024.2445083

Foreign Service Institute (FSI). (n.d.). *Language learning difficulty for English speakers.* U.S. Department of State. Retrieved August 7, 2025, from https://www.fsi-language-courses.org/blog/fsi-language-difficulty/

Fusch, P., Fusch, G., & Ness, L. (2018). Denzin's paradigm shift: Revisiting triangulation in qualitative research. *Journal of Social Change, 10*(1), 19–32. https://doi.org/10.5590/JOSC.2018.10.1.02

Ghaffar Ahmed, N., & Mwai, A. (2014). *The role of Finnish language in the integration process among immigrant women* (bachelor's thesis, Diaconia University of Applied Sciences). https://www.theseus.fi/handle/10024/73039

Gilodi, A., Albert, I., & Nienaber, B. (2024). Vulnerability in the context of migration: A critical overview and a new conceptual model. *Human Arenas, 7*(3), 620–640. https://doi.org/10.1007/s42087-022-00288-5

Giavrimis, P., & Dimitriadou, S. (2023). Interculturality in Greek education. *Journal of Ethnic and Cultural Studies*, *10*(3), 72-88. https://doi.org/10.29333/ejecs/1564

Glushkova, T., Kemppainen, L., Kouvonen, A., Wrede, S., Pietilä, I., & Kemppainen, T. (2025). Migration and diverse belongings in a neighbourhood context: Population-based study of older Russian-speaking migrants in Finland. *Population, Space and Place, 31*(1), e2877. https://doi.org/10.1002/psp.2877

Golubeva, I. (2025). *Diversity, equity, inclusion and intercultural citizenship in higher education.* Cambridge University Press. https://doi.org/10.1017/9781009442039

Gube, J., & Arat, G. (2024). Building social justice-oriented resilience for diversity, equity, and inclusion in higher education. *Journal of Ethnic and Cultural Studies*, *11*(4), 60-76. https://doi.org/10.29333/ejecs/1896

Hahl, K., & Paavola, H**.** (2015). To get a foot in the door: New host country educated immigrant teachers' perceptions of their employability in Finland. *Australian Journal of Teacher Education, 40*(3), 36–51. https://doi.org/10.3316/ielapa.072150995127481

Hamidullah, M. F., Piatak, J. S., & Chen, Y. (2024). DEI and human resources management. In R. O'Leary, J. L. Perry, & D. M. Riccucci (Eds.), *Handbook on diversity, equity, and inclusion in public administration* (pp. 125–144). Edward Elgar Publishing. https://doi.org/10.4337/9781802206173.00020

Hayter, C. (2009). *Cultural and linguistic inclusion? Literature review on social inclusion, cohesion, and culture.* National Ethnic Disability Alliance. https://apo.org.au/node/2513

Helsinki Times. (2016, March 9). Finns speak English—but how well? https://www.helsinkitimes.fi/finland/finland-news/domestic/13600

Hietalahti, A. (2022). *The impact of language skills on acculturation and employment of immigrants in Finland: A case study of students in vocational education and training* (master's thesis, University of Eastern Finland). http://urn.fi/urn:nbn:fi:uef-20221287

Hosseini, Z. (in press). Conceptualizing trust in public services: Migrant perception on urban inclusion in Finland. *Cities.* [In review]

Hosseini, Z. (2026). *Migrants' trust, equity, and inclusion in digital public services: A focus on information access and use*. In R. Cabecinhas, L. Lins, & I. Macedo (Eds.), *Migrações e comunicação na era planetária: Debates e ações* [Migrations and communication in the planetary era: Debates and actions]. (pp. 81-95). UMinho Editora. https://doi.org/10.21814/uminho.ed.196.6

Hosseini, Z., & Hytönen, K. (2022). A pedagogical approach for socio-cultural inclusion: A study on immigrant entrepreneurs in Finland. In M. Carmo (Ed.), *Education and new developments 2022* (pp. 426–430). InScience Press. https://doi.org/10.36315/2022v2end094

Hosseini, Z., & Kotilainen, S. (2021). The role of communication as the drive for immigration: A case study of Iranian international students in Finland. In M. Carmo (Ed.), *Education and new developments 2021* (pp. 390–395). InScience Press. https://doi.org/10.36315/2021end083

Hosseini, Z., Kotilainen, S., & Okkonen, J. (2020). The potential of social media to enhance cultural adaptation: A study on Iranian students in the Finnish context. In Á. Rocha, C. Ferrás, C. Montenegro Marín, & V. Medina García (Eds.), *Information technology and systems* (Vol. 1137, pp. 535–549). Springer. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-40690-5_52

Hosseini, Z., & Mehdizadeh, M. (2025*). Inclusive design considerations and strategies for digital services: An educational perspective. In World Conference on Information Systems for Business Management* (pp. 29–39). Springer. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-981-96-1744-9_4

Copyright 2026
ISSN: 2149-1291

Hosseini, Z., & Olsson, T. (2025). Epistemic uncertainty and ethical dilemmas in cross-cultural research. *Culture Crossroads, 31,* 143-159. https://doi.org/10.55877/cc.vol31.512

Hosseini, Z., & Tupasela, A. (2025, January). *Inclusive AI-based chatbots for public services in Finland: Potential of constructivism. In The Barcelona Conference on Arts, Media & Culture: 2024, Official Conference Proceedings* (pp. 159–175). https://doi.org/10.22492/issn.2435-9475.2024.16

Hudelson, P., Kolly, V., & Perneger, T. (2010). Patients' perceptions of discrimination during hospitalization. *Health Expectations, 13*(1), 24–32. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1369-7625.2009.00577.x

Hussain, M., & Jones, J. M. (2021). Discrimination, diversity, and sense of belonging: Experiences of students of color. *Journal of Diversity in Higher Education, 14*(1), 63–71. https://doi.org/10.1037/dhe0000117

Iikkanen, P. (2017). The use of language in migrant stay-at-home parents' process of integration: Experiences of inclusion and exclusion. *Journal of Applied Language Studies, 11*(3), 121–142. https://doi.org/10.17011/apples/urn.201712104587

Ismail, A. A. (2023). "I live in agony": The everyday insecurity of rejected Somali asylum-seekers in Finland. *Journal of International Migration and Integration, 24*(4), 1917–1937. https://doi.org/10.1007/s12134-023-01048-2

Kalogrides, D. (2009). Generational status and academic achievement among Latino high school students: Evaluating the segmented assimilation theory. *Sociological Perspectives, 52*(2), 159–183. https://doi.org/10.1525/sop.2009.52.2.159

Karanja, J. K. (2019). Immigrant women in Finland—Self-reported perception on education, health, employment and gender violence (master's thesis). University of Eastern Africa Baraton, Kenya. https://urn.fi/URN:NBN:fi:amk-2019052712178

KC, S., Clarke, K., & Seppänen, M. (2023). A scoping review on ageing migrants in Finland through the lens of intersectionality and vulnerability. *Nordic Journal of Migration Research, 13*(3), 1–18. https://doi.org/10.33134/njmr.561

Kontkanen, Y. (2024). Legitimate peripheral entrepreneuring: Somali immigrant entrepreneuring in Finland and in the United States (Doctoral dissertation, Itä-Suomen yliopisto). https://doi.org/10.3390/ijerph18052601

Kupriianova, L., & Kupriianova, D. (2023). Dar multilingua—Multipersonalia, key practice for social inclusion of migrants, refugees, and forcibly displaced persons. *Scientific Collection «InterConf», (180),* 82–93. https://archive.interconf.center/index.php/conference-proceeding/article/view/4795

Language Network. (n.d.). DEI: How to build inclusive communities through language. https://language.network/blog/dei-how-to-build-inclusive-communities

Laurén, J. S. I., & Wrede, S. (2008). Immigrants in care work: Ethnic hierarchies and work distribution. *Finnish Journal of Ethnicity and Migration, 3*(3), 20–31. http://www.etmu.fi/fjem/pdf/FJEM_3_2008.pdf

Leinamo, L. (2022). You can do without Finnish but I'm not sure I would want to: Working migrants' perceptions of the use and importance of English in Finland (bachelor's thesis). University of Jyväskylä. http://urn.fi/URN:NBN:fi:jyu-202208053990

Leppänen, S., Pitkänen-Huhta, A., Nikula, T., Kytölä, S., Törmäkangas, T., Nissinen, K., ... & Jousmäki, H. (2011). National survey on the English language in Finland: Uses, meanings and attitudes. *Studies in Variation, Contacts and Change in English (eVarieng).* https://varieng.helsinki.fi/series/volumes/05/

Li, G. (2013). Immigrant language acquisition: An international review. In *Routledge international handbook of migration studies* (pp. 286–297). https://doi.org/10.4324/9780203863299-37

Li, J., & Wang, Y. (2024). How public service accessibility affects health of migrants: Evidence from China. *Risk Management and Healthcare Policy,* 17, 3065–3084. https://doi.org/10.2147/RMHP.S475634

Marchi, M., Magarini, F. M., Chiarenza, A., Galeazzi, G. M., Paloma, V., Garrido, R., ... & Derluyn, I. (2022). Experience of discrimination during COVID-19 pandemic: The impact of public health measures and psychological distress among refugees and other migrants in Europe. *BMC Public Health, 22*(1), 942. https://doi.org/10.1186/s12889-022-13370-y

Markova, E. (2009). The 'insider' position: Ethical dilemmas and methodological concerns in researching undocumented migrants with the same ethnic background. In *The ethics of migration research methodology: Dealing with vulnerable immigrants* (pp. 141–154). https://doi.org/10.2307/jj.18427157.10

Merikoski, P. (2021). At least they are welcome in my home! Contentious hospitality in home accommodation of asylum seekers in Finland. *Citizenship Studies, 25*(1), 90–105. https://doi.org/10.1080/13621025.2020.1769558

Migrant Career. (n.d.). *Why networking is crucial for new migrants and how to do it right.* MigrantCareer.com. https://migrantcareer.com/why-networking-is-crucial-for-new-migrants-and-how-to-do-it-right/

Migration Policy Institute. (2021, November 5). *The changing concepts around immigrant integration.* Migration Policy Institute. Retrieved June 11, 2025, from https://www.migrationpolicy.org/article/measure-immigrants-integration-metrics-changing-thinking

Ministry of Justice. (2021). *Discrimination in Finland 2017–2019: Data report.* http://urn.fi/URN:ISBN:978-952-259-880-6

Ministry of Justice. (1999, latest amendments in 2018). *The Constitution of Finland.* Ministry of Justice. https://www.finlex.fi/en/laki/kaannokset/1999/en19990731.pdf

MIPEX. (2024). *Migration integration policy index 2020: Finland.* https://www.mipex.eu/finland#

Mohamed, A. A. (2024). *Challenges of belonging: Somali families' experiences with Finnish social services* [master's thesis, Diaconia University of Applied Sciences]. Theseus. https://www.theseus.fi/bitstream/handle/10024/856850/Mohamed_Ayan.pdf?sequence=2

Mohammadi, S. (2022). Social inclusion of newly arrived female asylum seekers and refugees through a community sport initiative: The case of Bike Bridge. In *The potential of community sport for social inclusion* (pp. 205–222). Routledge. https://doi.org/10.1080/17430437.2019.1565391

Mölsä, M. E., Tiilikainen, M., & Punamäki, R.-L. (2019). Usage of healthcare services and preference for mental healthcare among older Somali in Finland. *Ethnicity & Health, 24*(6), 607–622. https://doi.org/10.1080/13557858.2017.1346182

Ndomo, Q., & Lillie, N. (2023). Resistance is useless! (And so are resilience and reworking): Migrants in the Finnish labor market. In I. Isaakyan, A. Triandafyllidou, & S. Baglioni (Eds.), *Immigrant and asylum seekers labor market integration upon arrival: NowHereLand: A biographical perspective* (pp. 161–184). Springer. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-031-14009-9_7

Ndomo, Q. (2024). *The working underclass: Highly educated migrants on the fringes of the Finnish labour market* [Doctoral dissertation, University of Jyväskylä]. JYU Dissertations.

Neyer, A. K., & Harzing, A. W. (2008). The impact of culture on interactions: Five lessons learned from the European Commission. *European Management Journal, 26*(5), 325–334. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.emj.2008.05.005

Copyright 2026
ISSN: 2149-1291

Ng, E., Fitzsimmons, T., Kulkarni, M., Ozturk, M. B., April, K., Banerjee, R., & Muhr, S. L. (2025). The anti-DEI agenda: Navigating the impact of Trump's second term on diversity, equity and inclusion. *Equality, Diversity and Inclusion: An International Journal, 44*(2), 137–150. https://doi.org/10.1108/EDI-02-2025-0116

Nguyen, L. A., Evan, R., Chaudhuri, S., Hagen, M., & Williams, D. (2023). Inclusion in the workplace: An integrative literature review. *European Journal of Training and Development*. Advance online publication. https://doi.org/10.1108/EJTD-10-2022-0104

Nichols, S., & Virsinger, P. (2021). *"Always standing on the fragile side of ice": Immigrants' integration into the labor market in Finland – Report.* https://www.tek.fi/sites/default/files/attachments/immigrants_integration_into_the_labor_market_in_finland_2021.pdf

Nordic Co-operation. (2019). *Immigrants in the Nordic countries.* http://www.norden.org/en/statistics/immigrants-nordic-countries-0

Nshom, E., Sadaf, S., & Ilkhom, K. (2022). Perceived challenges living and integrating into Finnish society: A study among immigrants in Finland. *Journal of Intercultural Communication, 22*(3), 31–42. https://doi.org/10.36923/jicc.v22i3.82

Nykänen, N., & Raivio, H. (2013). *Quality services and socially responsible work: European good practices for increasing labour market inclusion.* https://www.julkari.fi/bitstream/handle/10024/116082/TOHKE_esite_A5_eng_web.pdf?sequence=1

Nyström, S., Fejes, A., & Mešić, N. (2023). Social inclusion beyond education and work: Migrants' meaning making towards social inclusion. *Social Inclusion, 11*(4), 5–12. https://doi.org/10.17645/si.v11i4.6984

Olivares, A., & Piatak, J. (2022). Exhibiting inclusion: An examination of race, ethnicity, and museum participation. *VOLUNTAS: International Journal of Voluntary and Nonprofit Organizations, 33*(1), 121–133. https://doi.org/10.1007/s11266-021-00322-0

Paananen, S. (1999). *Suomalaisuuden armoilla: Ulkomaalaisten työnhakijoiden luokittelu* (Tilastokeskuksen tutkimuksia 228) [Doctoral dissertation, University of Jyväskylä]. University of Jyväskylä. https://jyu.finna.fi/Record/jykdok.814907

Pehkonen, A. (2006). Immigrants' paths to employment in Finland. *Finnish Yearbook of Population Research, 42*, 113–128. https://doi.org/10.23979/fypr.45029

Peterson, E. (2022a). Views on "good English" and "Nordic exceptionalism" in Finland. *Frontiers in Communication, 7,* 803922. https://doi.org/10.3389/fcomm.2022.803922

Peterson, E. (2022b). The English language in Finland: Tool of modernity or tool of coloniality? In J. Hoegaerts, T. Liimatainen, L. Hekanaho, & E. Peterson (Eds.), *Finnishness, whiteness and coloniality* (pp. 267–289). Helsinki University Press. https://hup.fi/chapters/e/10.33134/HUP-17-11

Polavieja, J. G., Lancee, B., Ramos, M., Veit, S., & Yemane, R. (2023). In your face: A comparative field experiment on racial discrimination in Europe. *Socio-Economic Review, 21*(3), 1551–1578. https://doi.org/10.1093/ser/mwad009

Probyn-Rapsey, F. (2021). Feminist Protest and the Anthropocene. *Feminist Encounters: A Journal of Critical Studies in Culture and Politics, 5*(1), 02. https://doi.org/10.20897/femenc/9739

Prashar, A. (2025). Integrating diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) into operations and supply chains: Conceptual framework and research propositions. *Corporate Social Responsibility and Environmental Management*. Advance online publication. https://doi.org/10.1002/csr.70053

Quirke, L. (2012). Information practices in newcomer settlement: A study of Afghan immigrant and refugee youth in Toronto. In *Proceedings of the 2012 iConference* (pp. 535–537). https://doi.org/10.1145/2132176.2132278

Raento, P., & Husso, K. (2001). Cultural diversity in Finland. *Fennia, 180*(1–2), 151–164. https://fennia.journal.fi/article/view/3773/3564

Röder, A., & Mühlau, P. (2011). Discrimination, exclusion and immigrants' confidence in public institutions in Europe. *European Societies, 13*(4), 535–557. https://doi.org/10.1080/14616696.2011.597869

Rogova, L. (2014). The key to integration? A study of language as a policy strategy for social integration of immigrants in Sweden [master's thesis, Lund University]. https://core.ac.uk/download/pdf/289951052.pdf

Sabour, M. H. (2023). *Intercultural communication in the European context: Migration, education, and integration.* Routledge. https://doi.org/10.4324/9781315577746

Safarov, N. (2024). Administrative literacy in the digital welfare state: Migrants navigating access to public services in Finland. *Social Policy and Society, 23*(4), 908–921. https://doi.org/10.1017/S1474746423000076

Salgado, L., & Patuzzi, L. (2022). Promoting the inclusion of Europe's migrants and minorities in arts and culture. Migration Policy Institute. https://www.migrationpolicy.org/research/europe-migrants-minorities-arts-culture

Sgaramella, T. M., Zammitti, A., & Magnano, P. (2024). Navigating adult life from emerging to middle adulthood: Patterns of systemic influences and time perspective in migrants. *Behavioral Sciences, 14*(2), 86. https://doi.org/10.3390/bs14020086

Shah, R. (2024). Conducting qualitative interviews online and in-person: Issues of rapport building and trust. *International Quarterly for Asian Studies, 55*(4), 537–558. https://doi.org/10.11588/iqas.2024.4.24580

Shangguan, Z., Wang, M. Y., Huang, J., Shi, G., Song, L., & Sun, Z. (2019). Study on social integration identification and characteristics of migrants from "Yangtze River to Huaihe River" project: A time-driven perspective. *Sustainability, 12*(1), 211. https://doi.org/10.3390/su12010211

Shaymardanov, M., Heikkinen, S., & Lämsä, A. M. (2023). Social networks of women in organizations: Evolution of research and future research agenda. *South Asian Journal of Business and Management Cases, 12*(1), 97–112. https://doi.org/10.1177/22779779231154647

Sitra. (2017). *Työelämätutkimus 2017: Somen kautta voi löytää töitä tai tulla löydetyksi.* https://www.sitra.fi/uutiset/tyoelamatutkimus-2017-yli-puolet-suomalaisista-vahtanut-ammattia-tai-alaa/

Slonim-Nevo, V., Mirsky, J., Rubinstein, L., & Nauck, B. (2009). The impact of familial and environmental factors on the adjustment of immigrants: A longitudinal study. *Journal of Family Issues, 30*(1), 92–123. https://doi.org/10.1177/0192513X08324575

Sónia, L. (2012). From exclusion to inclusion going through segregation and integration: The role of the school and of the sociopedagogical mediator. *Procedia – Social and Behavioral Sciences, 69,* 47–53. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.sbspro.2012.11.382

Stasulane, A. (2024). Migration and youth: The lived experiences of Russian youth in Finland. *Social Sciences, 13*(4), 201. https://doi.org/10.3390/socsci13040201

Stephen, E. (2024). Migrants and integration: Is it towards a more pragmatic Finland? *SN Social Sciences, 4*, 227. https://doi.org/10.1007/s43545-024-01026-0

Thakur, K. (2025). Challenges and opportunities for international students in the Finnish job market (bachelor's thesis, Vaasan ammattikorkeakoulu University of Applied Sciences). https://urn.fi/URN:NBN:fi:amk-202505079559

Thanh, P. T., & Bao Duong, P. (2024). Vulnerability and resilience among women migrant street vendors during the COVID-19 pandemic. *Journal of Enterprising Communities:*

Copyright 2026
ISSN: 2149-1291

People and Places in the Global Economy, 18(3), 624–645. https://doi.org/10.1108/JEC-09-2022-0135

Tyrberg, M. (2024). The impact of discrimination and support on immigrant trust and belonging. *European Political Science Review, 16*(1), 18–34. https://doi.org/10.1017/S1755773923000139

United Nations. (n.d.). *United Nations Sustainable Development Goals*. Retrieved June 11, 2025, from https://sdgs.un.org/goals/goal16

Victor, O. (2025). Language and labour in the Finnish job market: Migrants' experiences on 'Finnish proficiency' shaping their employment and career. https://urn.fi/URN:NBN:fi:jyu-202506135321

Vissing, Y. (2025). The attack of diversity, equity and inclusion (DEI) as an attack on human rights education. In J. Zajda & Y. Vissing (Eds.), *Globalisation, human rights and education* (Vol. 51, pp. 53–71). Springer. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-031-80304-8_4

Wu, Z., & Finnsdottir, M. (2021). Perceived racial and cultural discrimination and sense of belonging in Canadian society. *Canadian Review of Sociology / Revue canadienne de sociologie, 58*(2), 229–249. https://doi.org/10.1111/cars.12339

Yle. (2024, February 14). THL survey: Over 40% of immigrants in Finland have faced discrimination. https://yle.fi/a/74-20079824

Yle. (2021, September 28). Union report: Migrants suffer lower pay, prejudice, discrimination in Finland. https://yle.fi/a/3-12114024

Zardo, F., Rössl, L., & Khoury, C. (2023). Adapting to crisis: The governance of public services for migrants and refugees during COVID-19 in four European cities. *Social Sciences, 12*(4), 213. https://doi.org/10.3390/socsci12040213

Zhang, N., Gereke, J., & Baldassarri, D. (2022). Everyday discrimination in public spaces: A field experiment in the Milan Metro. *European Sociological Review, 38*(5), 679–693. https://doi.org/10.1093/esr/jcac008

Zhou, M. (2014). Segmented assimilation and socio-economic integration of Chinese immigrant children in the USA. *Ethnic and Racial Studies, 37*(7), 1172–1183. https://doi.org/10.1080/01419870.2014.874566

Notes on Contributors

Zahra Hosseini holds a Ph.D. in Media and Communication and is currently a Postdoctoral Researcher at the Faculty of Social Sciences, University of Helsinki, where she works on the Trust-M project. Her research centers on migrants' experiences and their cultural inclusion. Email: zahra.hosseini@helsinki.fi

Amir Pakpour Haji Agha is a Doctoral Researcher in Information Technology at the Faculty of Information Technology and Communication Sciences at Tampere University. He is part of the Design group working on the Trust-M project. Email: amir.pakpourhajiagha@tuni.fi

Thomas Olsson is a Professor of Human-Centered Design at the Faculty of Information Technology and Communication Sciences, Tampere University, and leads the Design work package in the Trust-M project. Email: thomas.olsson@tuni.fi

ORCID

Zahra Hosseini, https://orcid.org/0000-0003-0423-8529
Amir Pakpour Haji Agha, https://orcid.org/0009-0002-4791-219X
Thomas Olsson, https://orcid.org/0000-0002-1106-2544